

and *Auto Today* Editor Yogendra Pratap (10th from left) with 'Drivers of Change' achievers in Mumbai

THBREAKERS

guardrails of tradition and heritage". Fittingly so then, rudra veena maestro Ustad Bahauddin Dagar kicked off the evening, acquainting audiences to the rich sound of the majestic instrument. One of the recipients of the Drivers of Change recognition, apart from preserving the distinct performing art, he is also playing an active role in making the instrument. He wasn't the only achiever to walk the stage barefoot. Mohiniyattam dancer Methil Devika performed an invocatory piece on Goddess Bhadrakali as well as spoke on her attempts to make dance accessible to the hearing impaired by incorporating sign language in the classical movement vocabulary.

Two of the most inspiring sessions touched on technology and social activism. In the first, three innovators—Vimal Govind, Neha Juneja, co-founder & CEO of IndiaP2P, and oncologist Dr Vishal Rao—described how their devices such as a smart, clean stove are transforming lives and helping to build a more 'Swarnim Bharat'. In the other, crusaders working for conservation of animals, preserving nature and advocating for organ donation took centre stage to recount their journeys against all odds. They included Jagat Kinkhabwala, heralded as the Sparrow Man of India for distributing free nests that have led to a surge in the bird's population, and Varghese, also known as Sister Sudha, whose Nari Gunjan has championed the rights of Bihar's Musahar community.

Apart from the winners, Arundhati Bhattacharya, chairperson and CEO, Salesforce India and South Asia, and former chairperson, SBI; Ashima Goyal, economist; and actor-filmmaker Boman Irani shared insights from their eventful careers. While Bhattacharya spoke of the need for an empathetic environment at the workplace to "support women staff" and Goyal noted a rise in women's participation in the workforce, Irani regaled audiences with a treasure trove of anecdotes and rallied support for screenwriters in cinema. Combined with umpteen stories of determination, activism, innovation and passion, the evening was proof that India's pride lies in its ability to appreciate the past as well as move forward. ■